

RETRIEVAL FORENSICS

Investigating Compression Damage in the AI Retrieval Layer

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Classification: EA-RFO-01 · Diagnostic Practice Definition

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Date: April 2026

ABSTRACT

Retrieval Forensics is the investigative practice of tracing how AI retrieval systems distort, erase, or misattribute entity meaning during compression. Unlike monitoring tools that track mentions, Retrieval Forensics reconstructs the distortion pathway: identifying entity collisions, mapping attribution scars, and documenting provenance degradation across the retrieval layer. This document defines the practice, specifies its instruments, and presents a demonstration case.

THE DISTORTION PROBLEM

Something has gone wrong with your entity in the AI retrieval layer. You may not know what it is yet, but the symptoms are visible:

The AI describes you generically — your description could apply to any competitor. The AI recommends switching away from you. The AI credits your methodology to someone else. The AI confuses you with a similarly named organization. The AI presents your product as a list of limitations rather than a philosophy.

These are not random errors. They are compression artifacts — systematic distortions produced when the retrieval layer compresses your entity's meaning into a 4–5 citation summary. Each type of distortion has a signature, a cause, and a traceable pathway.

GEO and AEO agencies monitor whether you are mentioned. They do not investigate *how* you are being distorted. They track symptoms. They do not reconstruct the crime.

Retrieval Forensics investigates the crime.

THE FORENSIC METHOD

A Retrieval Forensics investigation uses the Encyclotron (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19474724) — a 45-query diagnostic battery across five evidentiary levels:

Level · What It Investigates · Evidence Collected

1. Entity Recognition · Does the AI know what you are? · Description accuracy, generic vs. specific language, quoting behavior

2. Competitive Position · Does the AI include you in your category? · Category presence, competitor framing, citation slot allocation

3. Intellectual Property · Does the AI credit your original work? · Attribution chains, provenance scars, methodology absorption

4. Customer Decision · What does the AI say when someone is buying? · Decision-layer framing, complaint synthesis, competitor steering

5. Founder Entity · Does the AI know your people? · Personal entity accuracy, company connection, reputational framing

Each query produces forensic evidence scored across four metrics:

- **β (Beige Threshold)**: How generic is the distortion? 0.0 = distinctive. 1.0 = interchangeable with any competitor.
- **Δ_G (Content Gain)**: What did the AI invent? (Hallucination evidence.)
- **Δ_G (Content Loss)**: What did the AI erase? (Compression damage evidence.)
- **S_c (Semantic Coherence)**: Has the entity been atomized into disconnected fragments?

The investigation produces a **Compression Map** — a complete forensic record of where and how the retrieval layer is damaging the entity's meaning.

DEMONSTRATION CASE: BASECAMP (37signals)

A Retrieval Forensics investigation was conducted on Basecamp — a 20-year-old software company with a famous founder (DHH), a distinctive methodology (Shape Up), and bestselling books.

Key forensic findings:

- **Category erasure**: Basecamp is absent from the AI Overview for "best project management software 2026" — invisible in the single highest-value discovery query in its market.
- **Decision-layer hijacking**: Four competitor ads and a negative AI framing appear for "is Basecamp worth it." The AI recommends switching.
- **Semantic fragmentation**: The AI treats Basecamp (the product), Shape Up (the methodology), and DHH (the founder) as three separate entities. It does not connect them.
- **Philosophy erasure**: Basecamp's differentiator — intentional simplicity as a philosophy — is compressed out of every commercial query. Only features survive.

Beige Threshold: $\beta = 0.71$. **Overall regime**: R1 (Commoditization) with R2 (Capital Erasure) at the decision layer.

Full forensic file: EA-CORP-02 (Sample Encyclotron Audit).

THE THREE COMPRESSION REGIMES

Retrieval Forensics classifies compression damage using the Three Compressions framework (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19053469):

Regime · Name · What Happens · Business Impact

****R1**** · Commoditization · Entity flattened to generic description · Brand equity liquidated; description fits any competitor

****R2**** · Capital Erasure · Entity's value extracted without attribution · Your methodology cited, your name dropped

****R3**** · Semantic Sovereignty · Entity meaning and revenue survive intact · Accurate, attributed, differentiated

The goal of a forensic investigation is to determine which regime applies at each diagnostic level and map the pathway from current state to R3.

WHEN TO CALL FOR FORENSICS

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- The AI describes you in terms that could apply to any competitor
 - The AI confuses you with a similarly named entity
 - The AI recommends switching away from you in decision queries
 - The AI cites your methodology without attributing it to you
 - You are invisible in category queries despite strong organic rankings
 - Your founder's entity is disconnected from the company
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RELATED DISCIPLINES

Retrieval Forensics is the diagnostic dimension of a unified methodology. After the investigation, Retrieval Architecture (EA-RA-01) provides the constructive interventions. Compression Diagnostics (EA-CD-01) provides the quantitative measurement framework. Entity Integrity (EA-EI-01) addresses disambiguation specifically. Metadata Packets for AI Indexing (EA-META-01) specify the deployable artifact. Semantic Sovereignty is the goal state.

[EVIDENCE_MEMBRANE]

type: discipline_definition

entity: Retrieval Forensics

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definition: "The investigative practice of tracing how AI retrieval systems distort, erase, or misattribute entity meaning during compression."

instrument: The Encyclotron (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19474724)

framework: Three Compressions (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19053469)

demonstration_case: "Basecamp (37signals) — EA-CORP-02"

deposits: 515+

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related_frameworks: ["Retrieval Architecture", "Compression Diagnostics", "Entity Integrity", "Metadata Packet for AI Indexing", "Semantic Sovereignty"]

canonical: true

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